Advance Grammar for IELTS Exam

Rules & Examples — Quick Reference Guide

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1 Adjective Clause

An Adjective Clause (also called a Relative Clause) is a dependent clause that modifies a noun or pronoun. It usually begins with a relative pronoun (who, whom, whose, which, that) or a relative adverb (when, where, why).

Rules

- Placed immediately after the noun/pronoun it modifies.
- "Who / whom / whose" refer to people; "which" refers to things/animals; "that" can refer to both.
- "Whom" is used as an object; "who" is used as a subject.
- A comma is used with a non-restrictive (extra-information) clause, but not with a restrictive (essential) clause.
- The relative pronoun can be omitted when it is the object of the clause.

Examples

✔ *The man who called you yesterday is my uncle.*

✔ *This is the book that I borrowed from the library.*

✔ *My father, whose car broke down, took a taxi to work.*

✔ *Paris, which is the capital of France, attracts millions of tourists.*

✔ *The book (that) I bought last week is fantastic. (relative pronoun omitted)*

2 Noun Clause

A Noun Clause is a dependent clause that functions as a noun in a sentence. It can act as a subject, object, subject complement, or object of a preposition.

Rules

- Introduced by that, if/whether, or wh-words (what, who, which, when, where, why, how).
- Follows normal statement word order (no subject-verb inversion), even inside a question.
- Can function as the subject of the main verb: "What he said surprised everyone."
- Can function as the object of a verb or preposition: "I don't know what he wants."
- "That" introducing a noun clause can often be omitted in informal speech/writing.

Examples

✔ *What she decided remains a secret. (subject)*

✔ *I believe (that) honesty is the best policy. (object)*

✔ *The question is whether we can finish on time. (complement)*

✔ *He is interested in how the machine works. (object of preposition)*

✔ *Nobody knows where the treasure is hidden.*

3 Adverb Clause

An Adverb Clause is a dependent clause that functions as an adverb, modifying a verb, adjective, or another adverb. It expresses time, place, reason, condition, purpose, result, manner, contrast, or comparison.

Rules

- Begins with a subordinating conjunction (because, although, if, when, since, so that, as, while, etc.).
- Can appear at the beginning or the end of a sentence.
- When the adverb clause begins the sentence, it is followed by a comma.
- Answers questions such as when? where? why? how? to what extent? under what condition?

Examples

✔ *Because it was raining, we stayed indoors. (reason)*

✔ *If you study hard, you will pass the exam. (condition)*

✔ *She sang so beautifully that everyone applauded. (result)*

✔ *While I was cooking, the phone rang. (time)*

✔ *He ran as fast as he could. (manner/comparison)*

4 Clause of Concession

A Clause of Concession expresses a contrast or an unexpected result — it shows that something happens despite an opposing circumstance.

Rules

- Introduced by although, though, even though, while, whereas, despite/in spite of (+ noun/gerund).
- "Despite" and "in spite of" are followed by a noun phrase or gerund, NOT a full clause.
- "Although / though / even though" are followed by a full clause (subject + verb).
- "No matter how/what/who" + clause is also used to show concession.

Examples

✔ *Although he was tired, he kept working.*

✔ *Despite the heavy rain, the match continued.*

✔ *In spite of failing twice, she never gave up.*

✔ *Even though the price was high, people bought the product.*

✔ *No matter how hard I try, I can't solve this problem.*

5 Clause Reduction

Clause Reduction is the process of shortening a dependent clause into a phrase (usually a participle phrase) by removing the subject and the conjunction, and converting the verb into an -ing, -ed, or infinitive form. It creates more concise, academic-style sentences — very useful for IELTS Writing.

Rules

- The subject of the clause must be the same as the subject of the main clause.
- Active verb → present participle (-ing): "When he saw the police, he ran." → "Seeing the police, he ran."
- Passive verb → past participle (-ed/-en): "Because it was damaged, the car was sold cheaply." → "Damaged, the car was sold cheaply."
- Remove the subject and the subordinating conjunction if the meaning stays clear (conjunction can sometimes be kept for emphasis).

Examples

✔ *Full: While she was walking home, she found a wallet. → Reduced: Walking home, she found a wallet.*

✔ *Full: Because he was exhausted, he went to bed early. → Reduced: Exhausted, he went to bed early.*

✔ *Full: The students who are sitting in the front row are attentive. → Reduced: The students sitting in the front row are attentive.*

✔ *Full: After he finished his homework, he watched TV. → Reduced: Having finished his homework, he watched TV.*

6 Modifiers

A Modifier is a word, phrase, or clause that adds descriptive information to another element in a sentence. Correct placement of modifiers is essential for clarity in IELTS Writing.

Rules

- A modifier should be placed as close as possible to the word it modifies.
- Misplaced Modifier: a modifier positioned incorrectly, creating confusion or an unintended meaning.
- Dangling Modifier: an introductory phrase that does not logically modify the subject that follows it.
- Squinting Modifier: a modifier placed where it could logically modify either the preceding or following word.

Examples

✔ *Incorrect (dangling): Walking down the street, the trees looked beautiful.*

✔ *Correct: Walking down the street, I thought the trees looked beautiful.*

✔ *Incorrect (misplaced): She almost drove her kids to school every day. (suggests she rarely drove)*

✔ *Correct: She drove her kids to school almost every day.*

✔ *Correct: Covered in snow, the mountain looked magnificent.*

7 Coordinate Conjunction

Coordinating Conjunctions join words, phrases, or independent clauses of equal grammatical rank. Remembered by the acronym FANBOYS: For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So.

Rules

- When joining two independent clauses, a comma is placed before the conjunction.
- "For" means because; "So" shows result; "Yet" and "But" show contrast.
- "Nor" is used after a negative statement and requires inversion (auxiliary + subject).

Examples

✔ *I wanted to go for a walk, but it started to rain.*

✔ *She studied hard, so she passed the exam with distinction.*

✔ *He doesn't smoke, nor does he drink.*

✔ *You can have tea or coffee.*

✔ *The plan was risky, yet it worked perfectly.*

8 Subordinate Conjunction

A Subordinating Conjunction connects a dependent (subordinate) clause to an independent clause, showing a relationship such as time, cause, condition, contrast, or purpose.

Rules

- Common subordinators: because, since, as, although, though, if, unless, when, while, so that, in order that.
- The subordinate clause cannot stand alone as a complete sentence.
- It may come before or after the main clause; a comma is used when it comes first.

Examples

✔ *Since the weather was bad, the flight was delayed.*

✔ *Unless you hurry, you will miss the bus.*

✔ *She left early so that she could catch the train.*

✔ *Although it was expensive, he bought the laptop.*

✔ *We stayed inside because it was snowing heavily.*

9 Relative Pronoun

Relative Pronouns introduce adjective (relative) clauses and connect them to the noun they describe: who, whom, whose, which, that.

Rules

- Who — subject, refers to people.
- Whom — object, refers to people (formal).
- Whose — shows possession, for people or things.
- Which — refers to animals or things.
- That — refers to people, animals, or things; used mainly in restrictive (essential) clauses; never preceded by a comma.

Examples

✔ *The woman who lives next door is a doctor.*

✔ *The man whom you met yesterday is my boss.*

✔ *The student whose essay won the prize is in my class.*

✔ *The car, which was brand new, was stolen.*

✔ *This is the house that Jack built.*

10 Parallelism

Parallelism (Parallel Structure) requires that elements in a series or comparison share the same grammatical form — essential for clear, balanced sentences in IELTS Writing.

Rules

• Items joined by and, or, but must have the same grammatical structure (all gerunds, all infinitives, all nouns, etc.).

• Correlative conjunctions (not only...but also, either...or, neither...nor, both...and) must join equivalent structures.

• Comparisons using "than" or "as...as" must compare parallel elements.

Examples

✔ *Incorrect: She likes reading, swimming, and to cook.*

✔ *Correct: She likes reading, swimming, and cooking.*

✔ *Incorrect: He is not only intelligent but also he works hard.*

✔ *Correct: He is not only intelligent but also hardworking.*

✔ *Correct: Learning a language is as challenging as mastering a musical instrument.*

11 Inversion

Inversion reverses the normal subject-verb word order, usually by placing an auxiliary verb before the subject. It is often used for emphasis, after negative adverbials, or in formal conditional sentences — a hallmark of high-band IELTS Writing.

Rules

• After negative/restrictive adverbials at the start of a sentence (Never, Rarely, Seldom, Little, Not only, No sooner, Hardly): auxiliary + subject + verb.

• In formal conditionals, "if" can be dropped and the auxiliary inverted: Should / Were / Had + subject.

• After "so/such...that" when placed at the start of a sentence for emphasis.

Examples

✔ *Never have I seen such a beautiful sunset.*

✔ *Rarely does he arrive late for work.*

✔ *Not only did she win the race, but she also broke the record.*

✔ *Had I known earlier, I would have helped you. (= If I had known earlier...)*

✔ *Should you need any help, please contact us. (= If you should need...)*

✔ *So difficult was the exam that many students failed.*

Prepared as an IELTS advanced grammar reference — review each rule with its example, then practise writing your own sentences for maximum retention.